

and Manchester City, but he earned some breathing space after Kylian Mbappe and Rodrygo (**right**) scored in a 2-1 win against Deportivo Alaves to steer Los Blancos back to winning ways. The win, however, had little impact on the standings as Madrid remains second with 39 points from 17 games, with Villarreal breathing down its neck in third with 35 points from 15 matches.

League leader Barcelona has looked unstoppable in the league since the 1-2 El Clasico defeat in October and rode on a brace from Raphinha — who now has six La Liga goals this season — to cement its lead at the top.

Meanwhile, Antoine Griezmann, Atletico Madrid's record goalscorer, proved his class even at 34, scoring the winner as a substitute in a 2-1 win against Valencia. All his goals this season have come off the bench.

Bundesliga

Bayern Munich's Harry Kane (**below**) simply cannot seem to stop scoring, and that habit was on full display as he came on as a second-half substitute to bag a hat-trick and lead the Bavarians to a 5-0 thumping of VfB Stuttgart. The following week, he was once again called into action as he converted from the spot to draw level at 2-2 against Mainz, helping Bayern maintain its unbeaten start as well as a healthy nine-point lead at the top of the table, with RB Leipzig second (level on 29 points with Borussia Dortmund in third).

Meanwhile, both Leipzig and Dortmund failed to capitalise on the leaders dropping points for just the second time this season.

Leipzig fell to a 1-3 defeat against Union Berlin, while the Yellow and Black saw Jobe Bellingham sent off in their



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game against Freiburg before conceding an equaliser in a 2-2 draw.

Serie A

Defending champion Napoli held its own against giant Juventus, winning 2-1 — courtesy of a brace from Manchester United loanee Rasmus Hojlund — when the two sides met for the first time this season at the Diego Armando Maradona Stadium. However, Antonio Conte's side faltered the following week, failing to assume top spot after a 0-1 defeat to Udinese.

AC Milan has re-established itself as a title contender this season, and a major part of its success can be attributed to Christian Pulisic, who grabbed a match-winning brace against Torino to take his league tally to seven, one behind leader Lautaro Martinez.

Pulisic, however, had a goal disallowed in Milan's following game against Sassuolo, which ended 2-2, ruining the side's chance to go top.

Napoli and Milan dropping points left the door open for Inter Milan, which thrashed Como 4-0 before eking out a 2-1 win against Genoa, courtesy of goals from Yann Aurel Bisseck and Martinez.

Only two points separate the top three, with Inter on 33 points, followed by Milan and Napoli in second and third, respectively.

Ligue 1

RC Lens maintained its grip on first place in the French league with assured wins against OGC Nice and FC Nantes. However, it will be wary of record winner and defending champion Paris Saint-Germain, which recovered from its shock loss against Monaco and thrashed Stade Rennais 5-0, powered by Khvicha Kvaratskhelia's brace.

The Parisians, however, were forced to toil harder in their next match by FC Metz, which levelled after trailing by two goals. Golden Boy award winner Desire Doue then came off the bench to score the winner and take PSG up to 36 points, one behind Lens. Olympique de Marseille sits third (32) after bouncing back from its defeat against LOSC Lille to beat AS Monaco 1-0, thanks to Mason Greenwood's strike, which took him to a league-high 11 goals this campaign.